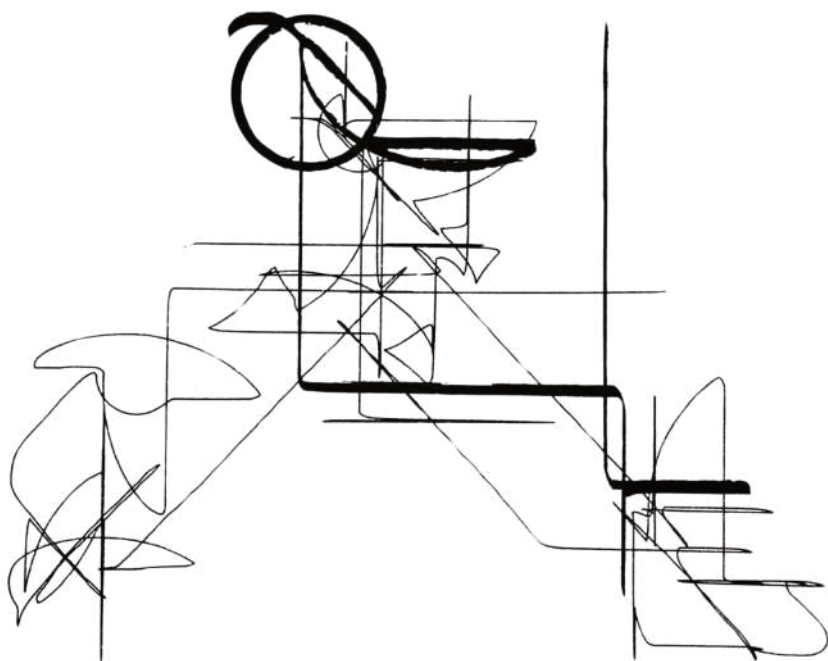


Issue 1: Human Computer Interaction



Machine
Zine

Letter from the Editor(s)

Welcome to the inaugural edition of Machine Zine!

To make a zine about human computer interaction in 2026 is, almost inevitably, to make a zine in the shadow of generative AI.

The current cultural language around AI often encourages mystification. Systems are described as if they think, imagine or create with autonomy. Rather than accepting the machine as an opaque source of wonder, these contributors examine it as a material, social and cultural system.

This zine is about machines as systems of constraint, negotiation and perception. It is not just about AI, but the longer cultural and artistic history of machines: analogue computers, drawing machines, ZX Spectrum sound, web identity, image generation, sensors, rooms, rules, interfaces and artistic practice.

Machines have never simply helped people make things. The machine as frictionless assistant has never existed. In practice, machines shape the conditions of making imposing systems that inevitably mark the work produced through them. This is true whether the work takes the form of an image, a sound, a drawing, a performance, an archive, an avatar or an online persona.

The zine is about human-machine relations after the fantasy of frictionless technology. It argues across articles that machines are not neutral tools. They are systems with histories, biases, material behaviours and cultural effects.

Machines are not external to culture. They are cultural systems. Artists should not merely use them, but test them, resist them, expose them and work with their limits.

-Sean Carroll, Co-director New Media Art Club

[HTTP://NEWMEDIAART.CLUB](http://newmediaart.club)

[@NEWMEDIAARTCLUB](http://newmediaart.club)

Table of Contents

EDITOR'S LETTER - 2

CONTRIBUTORS - 4

THE MOST INTERESTING MACHINES SAY 'NO', ANDY

JENKINSON - 5

ARCHITECTURE OF SUSPENDED NETWORKS AND IDENTITY

BOUND, DENISE PARDON BENITEZ & SEBASTIEN DURAND - 8

WE MUST ALL BE ARTISTS NOW, SEAN CLARK - 13

FRUITS OF LABOUR, SAVANNAH IRVING - 14

AN ARTISTIC COLLABORATION BETWEEN MAN AND MACHINE,

PAUL MAZZITELLI - 17

WE STAND BEFORE THE MACHINE: ROOMS, RULES, SYSTEMS,

AND THE THINKING MACHINES THAT ARRANGE US, TIMOTHY

ELLIM (TIMOTHY LIM) - 21

Contributors

ANDY JENKINSON

[HTTP://ANDYJENKINSON.COM/](http://andyjenkinson.com/) - ANDY JENKINSON IS A LEICESTER-BASED SOUND/MULTIDISCIPLINARY ARTIST WHOSE PRACTICE EXPLORES LEGACY TECHNOLOGY AND CONSTRAINT, INVESTIGATING HOW CREATIVITY EMERGES WHEN ARTISTS PUSH MACHINES BEYOND THEIR INTENDED LIMITS.

DENISE PARDON BENITEZ & SEBASTIEN DURAND

SINCE SEPTEMBER 2023, ARTIST-DUO SÉB AND DENISE HAVE EXPLORED VARIOUS ASPECTS OF THE HUMAN PSYCHE, DIGITAL MEDIA AND EXPERIMENTAL STORYTELLING IN THEIR PROJECT EXERCITIA SPIRITUALIA ANIMAE.
[HTTPS://JOURNAUXINDIENS.NET/](https://journauxindiens.net/) [HTTP://PADRON-BENITEZ.NET/](http://padron-benitez.net/)
[HTTPS://EXALTATIO-ANIMAE.NET/](https://exaltatio-animae.net/)

SEAN CLARK

SEAN CLARK IS AN INDEPENDENT ARTIST, CURATOR, AND RE-SEARCHER BASED IN LEICESTERSHIRE, UK. HIS ARTWORK EXPLORES INTERACTION AND CONNECTEDNESS THROUGH THE CONSTRUCTION OF AUDIOVISUAL SYSTEMS PRESENTED ON SCREEN, AS INSTALLATIONS, AND AS PRINTS.

SAVANNAH IRVING

MY ARTISTIC PRACTICE TAKES A MULTI DISCIPLINARY APPROACH TO MAKING WORK, EXPERIMENTING WITHIN DIGITAL AND ANALOGUE MEDIUMS LAYERING VISCERAL TEXTURE AND SATURATED COLOUR TO DISTORT AND RENDER SUBJECT MATTER.

PAUL MAZZITELLI

MY PRACTICE IS CYBERNETIC, INTERDISCIPLINARY AND COMPUTATIONAL. IT IS CYBERNETIC IN ITS ENGAGEMENT WITH SYSTEMS ART, FEEDBACK, SYSTEMS THEORY AND BEHAVIOUR. I AM INTERESTED IN HOW STRUCTURES REGULATE THEMSELVES, HOW INFORMATION CIRCULATES, AND HOW CONTROL AND ADAPTATION EMERGE THROUGH INTERACTION. I AM CURRENTLY STUDYING FOR AN MA IN FINE ART AT DE MONTFORT UNIVERSITY.

TIMOTHY ELLIM (TIMOTHY LIM)

TIMOTHY LIM IS A PRACTICE-BASED PHD RESEARCHER WHO WORKS ACROSS GAME STUDIES, PERFORMANCE, AND CREATIVE TECHNOLOGY. HIS PRACTICE EXAMINES HOW INTERACTIVE SYSTEMS SHAPE COOPERATION, MEANING-MAKING, AND PUBLIC EXPERIENCE IN CO-LOCATED ENVIRONMENTS.

The Most Interesting Machines Say ‘No’

ANDY JENKINSON

THE PROMISE OF FRICTIONLESS TOOLS

Creative technology now measures its success by how little resistance it offers. Intuitive user interfaces, optimised human-computer interaction, and seamless workflows promise less time spent mastering tools and more time spent on the work that matters: writing the book, making the music, drawing the picture.

Adobe, Apple, Unity, and the rest sell ease-of-use as a virtue. Presets and pre-built assets let you begin immediately; producing something recognisable within minutes. Basic tools handle everyday tasks, while increasingly complex features cater to the ‘power user’. Many now even offer AI suggestions for what you might want to do and how best to do it.

These experiences are often framed in terms of “cognitive ergonomics.” Reduce mental load. Remove obstacles. Enter a state of flow where the tool disappears entirely and the work pours out, effortlessly reflecting your intent.

Bollocks.

Friction is not a flaw. Friction is not a problem. To paraphrase Marshall McLuhan, friction is the medium.

Art emerges at the point we push against the constraints of the medium - or where it pushes back against us.

MACHINES THAT SAY NO

I contend with this in my artistic practice when writing new compositions for the 1982 ZX Spectrum, where every musical note exists only because a loop of instructions flips a tiny speaker on and off thousands of times a second. This machine offers no shortcuts - no sound chip, no timing circuitry - the pitch of notes is determined by the length of time the actual computing instructions take to operate.

Often I find myself attempting to achieve something within this system that breaks something else.

Adding a routine to check for keypresses might change the timing or pitch of a note. It becomes an exploration of what is possible versus what I can ‘get away’

with.

As I wrestle with this, I notice subtleties in the system's flaws, such as the poor frequency response of the ZX Spectrum's speaker. I tweak my music to exploit these, hiding complexities in the places where the limitations of the computer can 'do less damage'. The clock speed of the computer and the efficiency of my code limit the range of notes I can produce.

Internal registers being only 8-bit compromise the accuracy of tuning loops on high-pitched notes.

Solutions present themselves: I move to 16-bit register-pairs, but the extra computation time limits the maximum pitch. These micro-frictions shape the choices I make in the composition itself.

My frustration at the computer's lack of compliance is palpable.

My creative process is not a flow-state of music emerging unhindered from my soul - it is about overcoming barriers, negotiating, and making compromises over and over again.

The computer does its best to sabotage my artistic vision, and I adapt my work in response.

WORKING AGAINST THE MACHINE

My practice often involves working with technologies that are awkward, limited, and often deeply

unhelpful: the aforementioned ZX Spectrum computer, Teletext graphics systems, and GameBoy music software.

These machines do not behave like modern creative tools. They refuse convenience. They impose strict limits and strange rules. They require workarounds, hacks, and invention.

Creating Teletext art isn't simply a matter of placing pixels on its 80x72 grid, as it may outwardly appear. Foreground and background colours can't be changed simultaneously, and each change imposes a compromise: a 2x3 pixel gap of background colour, or a forced repetition of the previous 2x3 pixels to the left. The technical barrier to make a piece is low - placing the pixels is easy.

But fighting the restrictions is where the art emerges.

The constraints shape creations: refusing left-right symmetry, suggesting new framings, perspectives, and approaches to a piece. The Teletext art 'scene' may be small, but I can recognise other practitioners' work through the way they have navigated the systemic limitations - the stylistic scars left from their battles with the arcane conventions of the medium.